Indonesian mines without detailed deliberations and taking the Trusts into confidence, and his ‘ambivalent’ attitude on the Docomo issue, are cited as instances of this motive.

The second theory, though aired less publicly, attributes more disturbing motives to Mistry—that of taking over of the Tata Group in stages. This apprehension, shared by several Tata veterans, was that Mistry was working towards the implementation of a grand strategy whose foundations were laid by his father, Pallonji Shapoorji Mistry. For many, the history of the efforts of Pallonji family makes a compelling case for doubting the intentions of the group.

When Tata Sons was registered under the Indian Companies Act 1913 on 8 November 1917, a total of 2,075 shares were issued. Dorabji Tata, with 35 per cent of the shares, had the highest holding. He was followed by Ratan Tata, his younger brother, with 33 per cent. ‘Ruttonji D. Tata’ or Ratanji, JRD’s father and the son of Jamsetji’s maternal uncle, received 32 per cent. Only two shares, or 0.09 per cent, were allotted outside the family. It was an exception made for special reasons. The allocation of the shares of the company reveals that, for all practical purposes, Tata Sons was conceived, intended to be and constituted as a family entity as its name signified.

The two outside allottees were Ardeshir Billimoria and J.D. Ghandy. They became beneficiaries as they were closely associated with the group. The former was seen as a financial wizard whose ‘talents were recognized’ by Jamsetji himself. The latter, a partner of Wadia Ghandy & Co., was a solicitor who represented the group.

In the following year, one share was allotted to another outsider, F.M. Kanga, another solicitor who represented the group. In the next, three more shares were issued to individuals outside the family as they had distinguished themselves in the service of the company. One beneficiary was B.J. Padshah, whose services were requisitioned by Jamsetji for the establishment of the Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore.

The remaining two allottees were, surprisingly, foreigners. They became beneficiaries because of the contribution they made to the business interests of the company. The first allottee was John C.K. Peterson, a former ICS officer and controller of munitions and director of industries, Bengal, who later joined Tata Sons as director in 1919. He played a significant role in the affairs of TISCO.